

CAPSTONE PROJECT

Speaking We in Wartime: Pronominal Deixis and National Address in Ukrainian Facebook Poetry, 2014–2025

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Abstract

This paper tests whether first- and second-person pronoun rates shift within Ukrainian poets across the 24 February 2022 cutpoint. The analytic corpus comprises 1,601 Facebook poems by 105 authors (2014–2025), drawn from the larger Contemporary Ukrainian Poetry Archive of approximately 2,863 poems and stratified by Ukrainian- and Russian-language strata. Negative Binomial regression with poem-level word count as the exposure offset estimates corpus-level within-author effects and individual author slopes for first- and second-person singular and plural. Benjamini–Hochberg correction is applied within each language stratum and across the primary tests. We find a within-author increase in first-person plural rates in the Ukrainian-language stratum.....

KEYWORDS

Ukrainian Contemporary Poetry; Digital Humanities; Wartime Discourse; Pronominal Deixis; Within-Author Design

1. Introduction

On 24 February 2022, Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine triggered a born-digital iteration of a longer tradition of literature written under bombardment (Glaser 2020). Within days of the first missile strikes on Kyiv, poets were publishing short verse to their Facebook pages; within weeks, that flow had constituted what Glaser (2024) reads as an ongoing public conversation among writers, readers, and editors. The Contemporary Ukrainian Poetry Archive (Glaser and Lee 2024) now preserves this record. Much of the scholarship on resistance literature reads such writing as a discourse of national self-constitution rather than private lyric (Ilchuk 2017; Maksymchuk and Rosochinsky 2017). The Ukrainian case is unusual less in the writing than in its survival: a dated, machine-readable archive that admits statistical measurement at the scale of individual authors.

We focus on pronominal deixis: the grammatical means that position speaker, addressee, and adversary in social and political space. Critical linguistics treats these forms not as referential conveniences but as a principal grammatical site at which speech acts are tied to social and personal identities (Mühlhäusler and Harré 1990). Billig (1995) extends the claim: routine, unreflective uses of *we* and *our* continually flag, and thereby reproduce, the nation as an imagined community (Anderson 2006).

Slavic first-person plurals carry further referential load — the inclusive/exclusive distinction is typologically variable and pragmatically loaded ([Cysouw 2003](#); [Filimonova 2005](#); [Helmbrecht 2002](#)), but is not morphologically marked in Ukrainian

$$\alpha = 0.05$$

$$\Pr(\delta_i > 0 \mid)_q$$

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